

38 people with a rare disease told me how they manage a lifetime of medical records.

They don't have a way to.

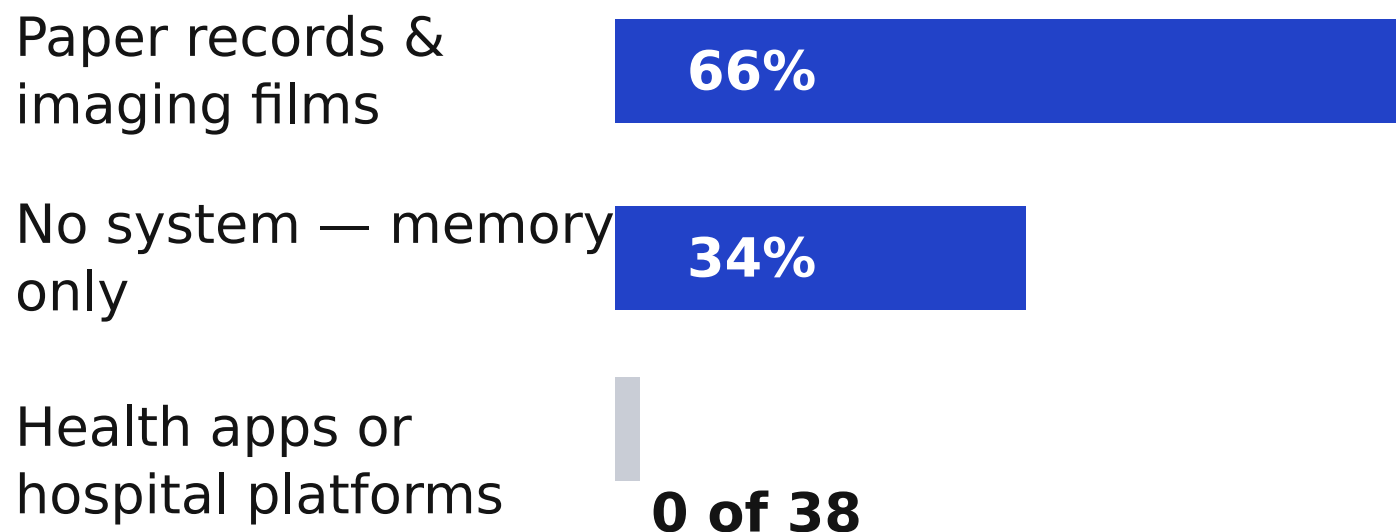
A patient-led UX study of China's NF2 community.

By Echo Zhao — data science master's student, living with NF2 myself.

FINDING 01 · THE RECORD-KEEPING GAP

100%

of respondents use **no structured digital tool** for a disease that demands lifelong MRI monitoring across multiple hospitals.



NF2 has no specialist centers in China — patients carry their own history from hospital to hospital. On paper. Or in their heads.

FINDING 02 · THE CONSULTATION BOTTLENECK

71%

hit **communication breakdowns** when they face a new doctor.

The #1 cause isn't medical — it's informational: **records too scattered to show years of progression inside a 10-minute consult** (37%).

And **76%** live with partial or total hearing loss — so the answer must be **visual by default**, not spoken.

FINDING 03 · WHAT PEOPLE SAY ≠ WHAT THEY DO

THEY SAY

50%

picked a **plain-language research library** as a top-2 must-have feature.

THEY DO

8%

actually consult literature when a new symptom appears. Most ask their doctor or their patient group instead.

Stated preference favors features people *imagine* using. Behavior points at the rare, high-stakes moment: **handing a new doctor your whole history, fast.** That's the moment worth designing for.

HONEST LIMITS & WHAT'S NEXT

n=38 is directional, not statistical. But NF2 affects ~1 in 33,000 people — 38 respondents and **29 interview volunteers** from one of the hardest-to-reach patient communities is access most research teams never get.

Next: 5–8 in-depth interviews, then a concept prototype — a patient-owned **disease timeline** that generates a **doctor-ready one-page summary**.

Working in accessibility, health UX, or rare-disease tech? I'd love to compare notes — DMs open.